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# What's God to a Man:
# The Honour of Achievements in Pokémon

*(TIMANDRA is hunched over a Nintendo DS. On screen, a ball rattles once, twice, thrice before it stills… a starburst appears. A helpful pop-up asserts: "Gotcha! AZELF was caught!")*

**TIMANDRA**

*(throwing the DS onto her bed with all the triumph of someone who has spent too long attempting to do something quite useless that they've decided to stake their ego on)*
Yessss, yes yes yes!

*(DIOTIMA looks up from her phone to stare as TIMANDRA punches and kicks the air a few times, then suddenly stops and scrambles for the dropped DS. TIMANDRA carefully navigates to the menu to save the game, then punches the air once more.)*

**TIMANDRA (CONT'D)**

*(smugly)*
Ha. Hope you enjoy your stay in my box after wasting eleven whole damn Ultra Balls!

**DIOTIMA**

*(sitting up suddenly)*
Are you serious?!? After all that, that, crying about not accidentally killing—

**TIMANDRA**

Fainting!

**DIOTIMA**

—the thingie, and paralyzing it and hitting it or whatever, after all that groaning and crying that made *me* nervous about catching it, you're not even going to use it?!?!

**TIMANDRA**

Wha- Obviously not! I'm not some ten-year-old kid who uses Legendaries to pwn everyone in battle!! I can win with Pokémon I've trained myself, thank you very much!

**DIOTIMA**

Then why in the world did you go through that incredibly tiresome process of catching it?!?!

**TIMANDRA**

It's a Legendary! It's an amazingly cool Pokémon with unique moves and unreal stats! And look at my Azelf, it even has a jolly nature—

**DIOTIMA**

*(gritting her teeth)*
Then use it!

**TIMANDRA**

*(taking a deep breath, trying to find an explanation)*
It's… too powerful to be used.
Azelf is a Legendary Pokémon which means it's just naturally powerful. Its base stats are higher to begin with. Using it to win in battle would feel like using an industry-grade diamond cutter to slice a mango.

**DIOTIMA**

Is this, um, Azwolf, so powerful that no one can defeat it?

**TIMANDRA**

*(rolling her eyes)*
Azelf. And of course not, did you not see how difficult it was for me to not immediately KO it?

**DIOTIMA**

Well, then, obviously it isn't *that* powerful. If it happens to have a bit of a power advantage compared to other Pokémon, so what?

**TIMANDRA**

It's not just about power! There's a lot of powerful Pokémon that aren't Legendaries. Like my Garchomp, did you see how it used False Swipe—

**DIOTIMA**

Focus.

**TIMANDRA**

Oh, fine. There's some Pokémon, like Garchomp, that are known as pseudo-Legendaries. They're not actually Legendaries, but they have really strong base stats and moves that are comparable to Legendaries.

**DIOTIMA**

So, don't you feel like… uh, how'd you put it? "Using an industry-grade diamond cutter to slice a mango" when you use Garchomp in battle?

**TIMANDRA**

*(puffing her chest out)*
Hell yeah I do, my Garchomp can defeat any Pokémon with just one Dragon Pulse.

*(DIOTIMA just looks at TIMANDRA, who realizes her hypocrisy.)*

**TIMANDRA (CONT'D)**

It's different, okay! I raised Garchomp from when way back when he was just a teeny-weeny Gible. *(fondly)* He could barely hold his own against a Buziel. But hours of training and gaining experience, here we are!

**DIOTIMA**

So, your issue is that it's unfair to use Legendaries because they don't involve any hard work?

**TIMANDRA**

(*gestures vigorously to the abandoned DS)*
No hard work?! I just spent ten minutes trying to catch Azelf!

**DIOTIMA**

Hard work in raising them, I mean.

**TIMANDRA**

Well, there are cases in which you can raise Legendaries… like in the game I'm playing, it's possible to find a level 1 Regigigas.

**DIOTIMA**

So, if another player used Regigigas in battle, would you think it's unfair?

**TIMANDRA**

Obviously there's no way of telling whether they raised the Regigigas themselves or just migrated the one found at level 100 or *(with disgust)* paid someone to trade their Regigigas to them.

**DIOTIMA**

*(nodding with all the wisdom of someone who has no idea of what was just said)*
Obviously.

**TIMANDRA**

But I think it's still unfair, because there's only one Regigigas in a game. The other characters can't catch it. So you still have an unfair advantage in the game, even if you had to put in the hard work of raising the Legendary.

**DIOTIMA**

Wait, why can't other people catch it?

**TIMANDRA**

Other <u>*people*</u> can, when they play the game as the protagonist. But other characters within the game can't because, you know, they're not the protagonist.

**DIOTIMA**

*(with renewed frustration)*
Are you serious?!?! Then why are we even arguing about what's unfair, you're not even fighting real people! They're just characters in a game quite literally made for you, so how does it matter if you unfairly play with Legendaries!!

**TIMANDRA**

*(musingly)*
That's harsh… Can I justify my unfair behaviour or intentions just because it's not directed at real people…? I'm still doing something unfair, right…

*(TIMANDRA notices DIOTIMA about to start yelling again, and quickly backtracks.)*

**TIMANDRA (CONT'D)**

Let's table that for now. How about I just say that it feels like a cop-out to use Legendaries? It's, I don't know, dishonourable—

**DIOTIMA**

*(snorts)*
Dishonourable!

**TIMANDRA**

Like, it's just too easy to win the game with extra-powerful Pokémon only I can acquire.

**DIOTIMA**

Well, I suppose I can agree that Legendary Pokémon do seem to provide a really easy means to win the game, if they're so powerful, don't need any training and can't be caught by other people.

**TIMANDRA**

*(reaching for her DS, excited to go back to gaming)*
Great! Now that you get it—

**DIOTIMA**

But.

**TIMANDRA**

*(groaning)*
Now what!

**DIOTIMA**

So what if using Legendaries is an easy means to win a game? Isn't the point of a game to win?

**TIMANDRA**

I just told you, it's *too* easy! Sure, I achieve the goal of defeating the Elite Four, but even a seven-year-old with hand-eye coordination could do it with a team of Legendaries. It's just a hollow victory.

**DIOTIMA**

An achievement is an achievement whether you're satisfied with it or not.

**TIMANDRA**

Yeah, but what good is something that gives me no satisfaction?

*(DIOTIMA, unconvinced, opens her mouth to pose another question, but TIMANDRA cuts her off.)*

**TIMANDRA (CONT'D)**

Look, you said it yourself earlier – Legendary Pokémon allow players to win through easy means. Winning through easy means isn't satisfying, and if it isn't satisfying, it isn't really a valuable achievement.

**DIOTIMA**

But that's the thing! Sometimes winning through easy means *is* satisfying.

*(DIOTIMA waits for TIMANDRA to begin arguing immediately, but there's no response. She eagerly continues when no answer is forthcoming.)*

**DIOTIMA (CONT'D)**

Like in Tetris, when you get the perfect straight piece that wipes out six rows by filling out the gap you made, it's pretty satisfying – even though it was easy.

**TIMANDRA**

*(reluctantly seeing DIOTIMA's point)*
Okay, it *is* satisfying. But not because it was easy!

**DIOTIMA**

What could be easier than just being given the correct piece – or, like, the Legendary Pokémon to you?!

**TIMANDRA**

But those aren't the same thing!
Like, for instance, in the Pokémon games, there's something called Pokérus. It's a virus that your Pokémon can get infected by that make them grow super-fast and it's insanely rare. It's really satisfying to get because of that rarity, and it makes winning the game easier, but in the end, it's just a matter of some probability equations embedded in the game.

**DIOTIMA**

So was catching Azelf! You could have caught it the first time instead of using eleven Ultra Balls, but it just so happened that the odds weren't working out.

**TIMANDRA**

Sure, but encountering Azelf in the first place is an inevitability. Pokérus isn't.

**DIOTIMA**

The fact that Pokey-rizz is—

**TIMANDRA**

Pokérus.

**DIOTIMA**

—less certain than a Legendary Pokémon doesn't change that it is an easy means to win the game and still provides satisfaction!
If one is a valuable achievement but the other isn't, then clearly you're just being pompous about using Legendaries.

*(TIMANDRA is stumped by this argument for a second. DIOTIMA smirks, smug at finally getting her point across.)*

**DIOTIMA**

*(teasingly)*
Pompous.

**TIMANDRA**

*(rolling her eyes*)
Okay, how's this: the satisfaction comes from overcoming the odds. The odds of beating the game without using Legendary Pokémon is lower than if I did use Legendary Pokémon.

**DIOTIMA**

Yeah, and it's also true that the odds of beating the game without Pokérus is lower than if you did have Pokérus.

**TIMANDRA**

But there's more satisfaction in beating the odds of gaining Pokérus in the first place.
If players used hacks or cheat codes to get Pokérus in every playthrough, then it would be just as dishonourable and unsatisfying to win using Pokérus as it is to win by using Legendaries.

**DIOTIMA**

So just because you win by beating the odds, it's a satisfying and valuable achievement?

**TIMANDRA**

Yeah, I'd say so.

**DIOTIMA**

But… you didn't *do* anything to gain Pokérus. You just happened to get lucky.

**TIMANDRA**

Yep, and I could choose to use or not use Legendaries to made the odds of me beating the game even more difficult.
I think if someone had Pokérus and chose not to use it, that would be an even more satisfying win, no?

**DIOTIMA**

…Fine.

*(TIMANDRA remains silent, but is wearing a very self-satisfied grin. DIOTIMA notices it and huffs.)*

**DIOTIMA (CONT'D)**

I'll eventually find a problem with this argument too, you know.

**TIMANDRA**

*(rolling her eyes)*
I'll be here when you do.

## Appendix

I'd like to acknowledge Martha Nussbaum who in her analysis of Plato's *Symposium* pointed out that Socrates' teacher in Love, 'Diotima', meaning 'honour the God', was a direct contrast to Alcibiades' consort Timandra, meaning 'honour the man'.

TIMANDRA's original argument $X_1$:

1. Legendary Pokémon are more powerful than the average Pokémon.
2. Legendary Pokémon do not need the player to train or evolve them after catching to be powerful.
3. Legendary Pokémon are available only to the player (and not their opponents).
4. If 1-3, Legendary Pokémon allow players to win a game through easy means.
5. Valuable achievements are achievements which provide satisfaction to the player.
6. It is not satisfying to win a game through easy means.
7. If 5-6, winning a game through easy means is not a valuable achievement.
8. If 4 and 7, using Legendary Pokémon to win a game is not a valuable achievement.
9. Using Legendary Pokémon to win a game is not a valuable achievement.

DIOTIMA's counterargument $X_{6'}$ to premise 6, reframed for Pokémon games:

1. Pokérus makes Pokémon stronger and more powerful than if they were not infected with Pokérus.
2. Pokérus does not need the player to exert any effort to gain it.
3. Pokérus is available only to certain players at certain times (and not their opponents).
4. If 1-3, Pokérus allows players to win a game through easy means.
5. It is satisfying to win a game using Pokémon infected with Pokérus.
6. If 4-5, it is satisfying to win a game through easy means.
7. It is satisfying to win a game through easy means.

TIMANDRA's amended argument $X_2$:

1. The odds of catching a Legendary Pokemon are high.
2. The odds of winning a Pokémon game without Legendaries is lower than if Legendaries were used.
3. The odds of gaining Pokérus are very low.
4. The odds of winning a Pokémon game without Pokérus is lower than with Pokérus.
5. If 1-4, the overall odds of winning a game with Pokérus is lower than winning a game with Legendaries.
6. Valuable achievements are achievements which provide satisfaction to the player.
7. It is more satisfying to overcome lower odds than higher odds.
8. If 6-7, winning a game by beating lower odds is a valuable achievement.
9. If 5 and 8, using Legendary Pokémon to win a game is not a valuable achievement but using Pokérus to win is a valuable achivement.
10. Using Legendary Pokémon to win a game is not a valuable achievement but using Pokérus to win is a valuable achivement.